



The initial thrust

Viet Cong troops charge from hiding places in the jungle during the initial phase of the Tet Offensive. Communist forces attacked more than 100 targets in South Vietnam.

Night raids

Due to communication problems, the attack actually began on January 30, a day earlier than scheduled, with raids on US and ARVN bases in towns in the Central Highlands and along the north coast. This led General Westmoreland to place US forces on high alert and South Vietnam's President Thieu to cancel ARVN leave. These measures were enough to quell the initial wave of attacks but not what was to come.

The main offensive erupted across South Vietnam in the early hours of January 31. The offensive, which included nearly every provincial capital and major city, was especially fierce in Saigon where around 5,000 Viet Cong attacked strategic targets around the capital, supported by North Vietnamese regulars in the countryside. Communist leaders were confident their forces would gain momentum as civilians rose up against the Americans and the Saigon regime.

“We have reached an important point when
the **end begins to come into view.**”

GENERAL WESTMORELAND ON THE TET OFFENSIVE, NOVEMBER 1967

Key targets

Dozens of South Vietnamese and American government buildings and bases were attacked between 2 and 3 a.m. Among the hardest hit were Tan Son Nhut airbase and the adjacent MACV compound, the headquarters of the US high command, nicknamed Pentagon East on account of its size and importance. Other targets included the presidential palace, the US Embassy, the ARVN headquarters, the national radio station, and the national police